



Computer and laptop repairs is an easy-to-set up business as these are built with easily replaceable PC boards and modules (Courtesy: <http://techpin.com>)

good network with venture capitalists, because if it is a bright idea, funding will surely be quick.

Subramaniam adds, "Another important thing would be to form a good team, and getting the right mix of people from various backgrounds. Since the majority of the team will largely be technical, it's very important to consider the financial and marketing aspects of the firm as well." Unfortunately, many students do not pay attention to aspects other than the technical. He adds, "They might have a great product in mind; however, they would not be able to answer queries like who they plan to sell to, how they plan to market the product, how to finance their project, or even how to go about manufacturing the product. Therefore it is better to first give it a lot of thought, answer all these questions and when everything is in place, they can go ahead with the project."

On the other hand, after all the thinking, if the students feel they lack the answers to any or all of these questions, it would be better for them to join a promising start-up. They must attempt to take on maximum responsibility for at least a couple of years because it is easy to learn or answer all the questions in one's mind at a start-up, believes Ganapathy Subramaniam. He says, "In fact, the team members must each try to take on more responsibilities, juggling multiple job func-

tions. If they were a part of an out-sized multinational company, they'd in all probability not get adequate exposure for their future business. I strongly advise students, curious about entrepreneurship as a career, to look for promising start-ups and take the maximum responsibility they can."

So the right thing to do would

be to understand the gaps in your business plan, try to fill these gaps with the help of seniors and industry experts, and then validate your idea and venture out to start the company. Subramaniam says, "When Apple, for instance, introduced the iPod, it wasn't that MP3 players didn't exist at that time. It required a pioneer like Steve Jobs to sell it, and Apple's top team to innovate on many features including the look and feel."

Sharing his experience, Chaddha says, "Normally what has been happening with most engineering graduates since the last four-five years is that they settle for IT jobs. Joining IT companies will definitely not give them the right exposure to be entrepreneurs at a later stage. I know at least 20 fresh engineering graduates who have started their own businesses while managing their graduation." He adds, "I would recommend engineers to work in a start-up in their second or third year itself as interns and understand the environment. Then they can start on their own immediately after they graduate, or even before that. But yes, they definitely do need some experience, which they can acquire only by working in a good start-up rather than a large organisation."

Ganesh Shankar shares his belief, "I think it is certainly beneficial to seek employment first (prior to launching a start-up) so as to get first-hand experi-

ence in problem solving in the industry, upgrade both technical and non-technical skills, and also build contacts in the supply chain. The bottom line is: Who is going to spend on the learning (read: mistakes) when you start your career? If you start a business right away, you have to pay for the learning yourself."

Is it worth the effort?

"Honestly, looking at the current employment figures, there is hardly any choice," believes Chaddha. He adds, "A recent article that I came across reported that 1.5 million engineers graduate every year, and only 150,000 jobs are available in large companies. So, the remaining engineers are either going to join a start-up, become entrepreneurs, or prepare for GATE and pursue a master's degree. Honestly speaking, even after the completion of their master's degree, most students are again in the same kind of situation."

So the bottom line is they need to have skills and guts. Chaddha says, "If you are looking for a very secure and stable life, yes, go ahead with a job. But if you want to be an entrepreneur, the instability and insecurity is definitely high initially, but it's much more fun."

Many students give up early. They must have patience and believe in their idea, feels Subramaniam. He says, "They shouldn't get frustrated, because it's going to be a tough journey, but the rewards will be very satisfying." Ganesh Shankar believes it will be rewarding both financially and professionally only if one is ready to pursue it for a long time, especially if you are talking about a business in manufacturing, repairs or assembly in the field of electronics. Making an important point, he says, "Unlike the Internet and mobile start-ups, these industries are capital intensive—you have got to get equipment, tools and assembly lines. It may take a while to break even and then make profit."

Is it a good time to start a business?

"The ESDM industry is a very large industry, even if you consider just the